

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Defense, Prophylaxis, and Counterplay

Find resources, reduce danger, prevent breaks, and stay active

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. What Did The Last Move Change?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Study the square a piece left as carefully as the square it reached.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

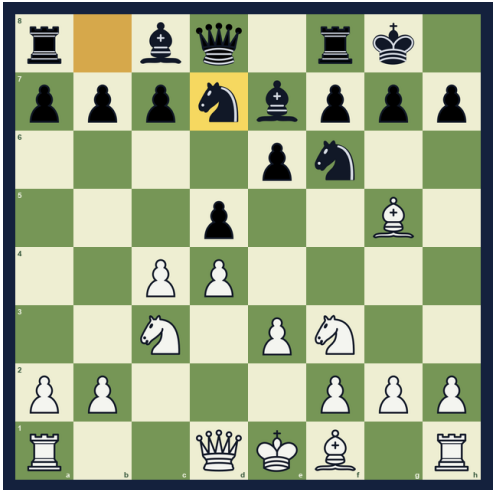
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Loose Pieces Tell The Truth



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Identify what is loose, then ask which forcing move can exploit it.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

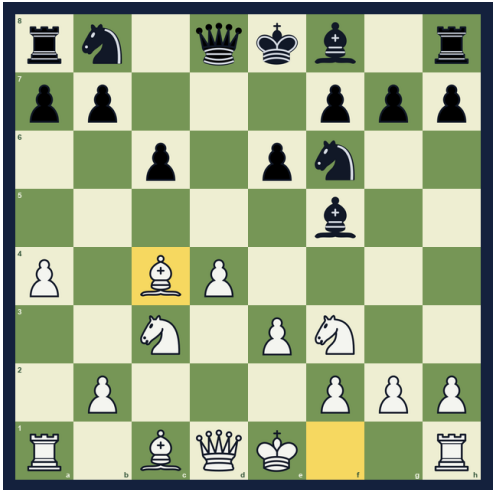
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Compare The Two Kings



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Compare access, defenders, and attacking pieces before opening lines.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

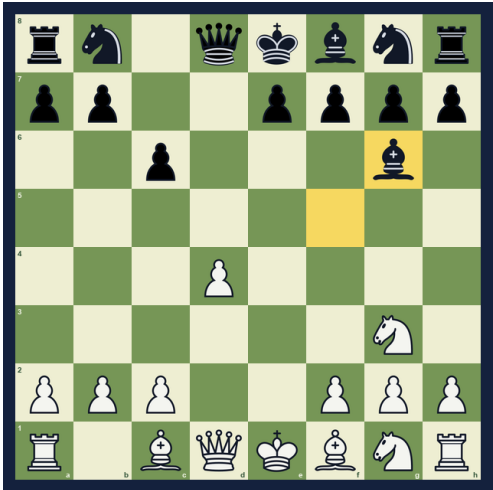
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Count Attackers And Defenders



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Include hidden defenders, pinned pieces, and the value of the final occupant.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

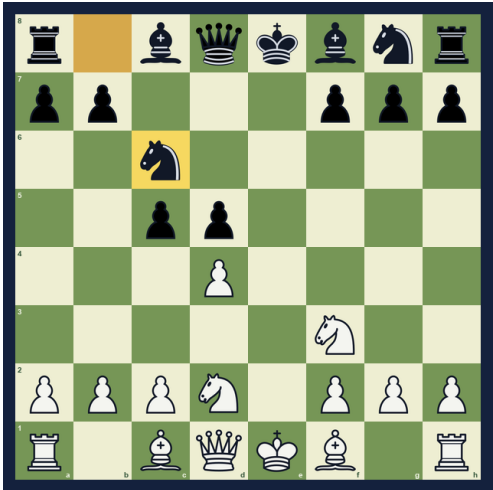
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. When To Trade Pieces



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Evaluate the position after the exchange, not the pieces disappearing from it.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. When Not To Trade Pieces



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Decline exchanges when your piece, space, or tension forces the opponent to remain uncomfortable.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Stop Counterplay Without Passivity



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Identify the freeing break, invasion square, or active piece that gives the opponent play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Keep Or Release The Tension?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Compare capture, advance, and waiting before changing the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Exchange The Best Defender



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Identify the piece whose removal changes the opponent's entire defensive geometry.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Forcing Moves With Purpose



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Generate forcing moves, then reject the ones that improve the opponent's position.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Continue until checks, captures, and immediate threats no longer control the next move.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Stop Calculating Ghost Threats



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Check access, consequence, and timing before investing calculation time.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

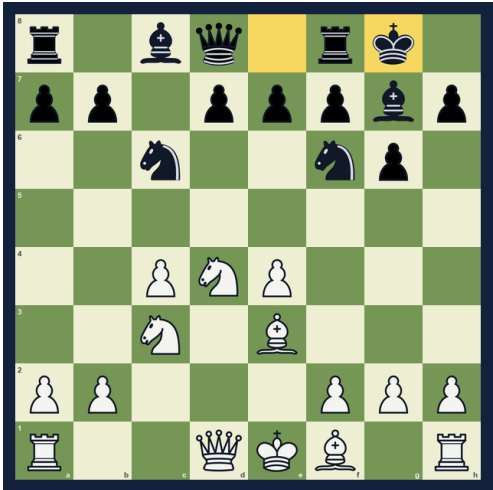
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FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Calculate Defensively



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Identify what makes the threat work, then block, trade, move, or counterattack that element.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

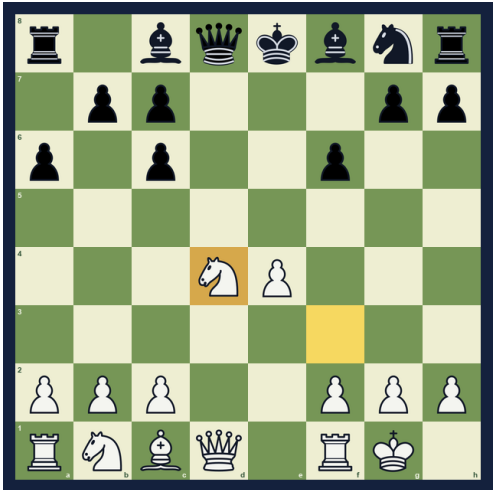
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. When To Calculate Deeply



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Calculate deeply when the move is forcing, irreversible, or changes the evaluation sharply.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

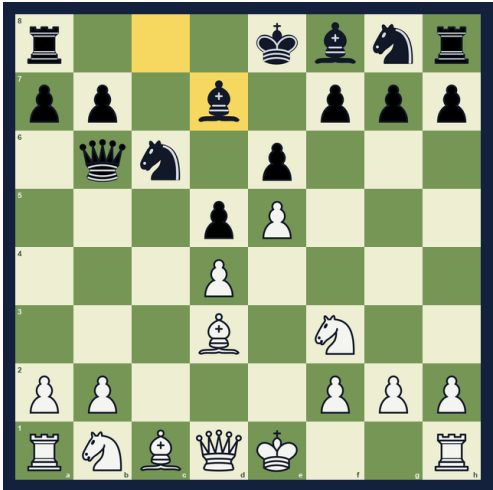
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Use Your Clock Like A Budget



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Use fast routines for familiar positions and deliberate budgets for irreversible choices.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

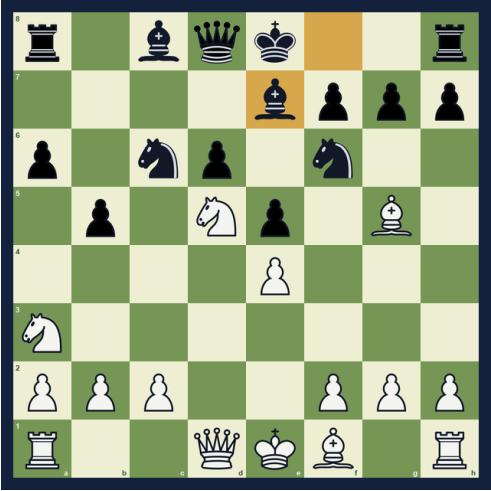
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Convert An Extra Pawn



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Activate the king and pieces, restrict counterplay, then use the majority to create a passed pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

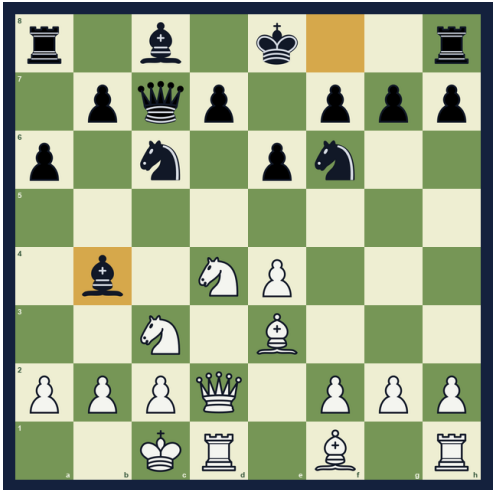
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Defend A Worse Position



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Reduce the opponent's easiest plan while preserving one source of counterplay.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

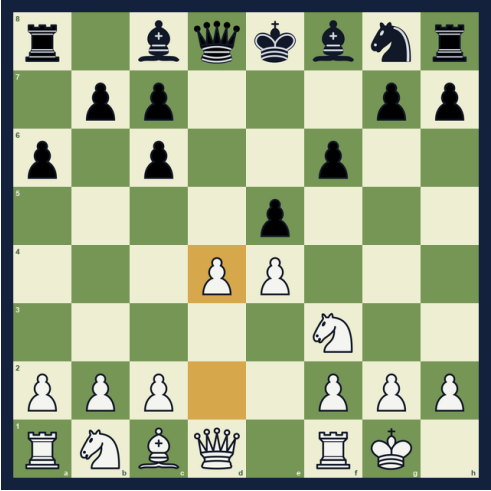
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. When You Have No Idea What To Do



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Remove immediate danger, improve the worst piece, or preserve useful options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

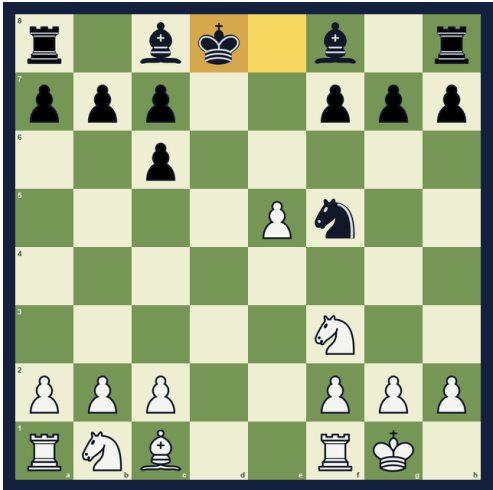
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Recover From A Bad Opening



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Finish development, protect the king, and challenge the opponent's most useful piece or space advantage.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.